

The role of new media in tourism industry development

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Abstract

Nowadays, mass communication new means (radio, TV, press, internet and etc) play an important role in progress and development of human culture and civilization by dissemination of information and knowledge, intellectual exchange and public beliefs. Since mass communication new tools offer expanded services we try to identify that how our authorities use this potential and what strategies they employ for development of country in different scopes such as tourist industry.

In other words, Iran has a lot of potentials in terms of tourist attractions, historical and cultural heritage and ecotourism and by little effort, it can enhance non-oil revenue from tourism sector significantly, but what are reasons for failure of this sector in Iran? Why some countries were able to develop their tourism industry and Iran with possessing required conditions has not achieved this important capacity?

Many factors contribute to a country's tourism development. Media is among the factors that play a significant role in this regard. Recently, the authorities have paid attention to "media" in this field.

Key words: media, mass communication, mass communication new means, tourism, tourism industry

Introduction

The word of tourism from tour is rooted in Latin word of turns that means going around and trip to specified destination. This word entered to Spanish and French and finally in English from Greek.

Tourism is one of the largest and most profitable industries in many countries of the world. With an ancient history and a variety of attractions and regional opportunities for economic benefits including job creation and foreign exchange earnings, Iran emphasizes on the preservation of high values and cultural identity and civilization. Despite the richness and diversity of Iranian culture, civilization and customs, Iran has not gained specified place and has not proportionate share in tourism industry.

Recently, many countries have found a new approach in tourism as the latest economic and social issue and they have identified social, industrial capacities along with economic development and they have shown increasing willingness toward tourism as a strategic industry and even profitable industry (Moayerinejad, 2009, available at : <http://khabaronline.ir/news>).

Today, this industry is so profitable that some countries could have earned as much as countries with oil income. Tourism has been expanded in different recreational, and specialist sectors and it is necessary to consider it in broad way. One of the important sectors gained less attention in Iran is utilization of communicating potential for tourism development in the local, regional and trans-regional scopes.

In other words, different tourism journals and magazines have been published but they could not gain public attention due to lack of correct management and support of organization. It can be said that Iran's neighbor countries have tried to attract tourists by advertisement in media and even it has been led that most of the Iranians travel to these countries instead of visiting their natural and historical attractions"(Ebtakar newspaper, 2007, no. 886).

Accordingly, this paper tries to investigate media's role in the development of tourism and identify its place among Islamic countries, including Iran and tries to consider the media's role in the development of societies and employing new technologies for tourist's attraction and identify problems of this industry and find solution for it.

Problem statement

Nowadays, tourism has gained extremely important position in the world, to the extent that it is seen as an industry. So that tourism is one of the most important industries for expansion of cultures and communication in developing countries and it plays a main role in establishment of peace in the world. Strategic value that tourism can bring to the geo-strategic countries is not comparable with any industry and technology.

Although, contemporary period is called communication and information era, no industry could be developed in universal competitive scope without employing mass communication new means and alignment with shifts and tourism is not optional in this regard.

Hypothesis

The main hypothesis of this study is that there is a significant relationship between use of modern means of mass communication and tourism development.

In this hypothesis different theories like cultivation theory have been used. In this theory, it is believed that media influence on individuals and make them to be the same by predefined goals with omission of personal knowledge and awareness and shaping the audience value system - as new approach refers to it - or an approach that emphasizes on use and meeting needs of the audience and type of media used and acceptance and modeling of its content focuses.

Research objectives **General objectives**

In terms of tourist attractions, historical and cultural heritage and ecotourism Iran has a lot of potentials and non-oil revenue can be increased by tourism greatly, but why Iran cannot achieve this goal? Why some countries were able to develop their tourism industry and our country with possessing required conditions has not achieved this important capability? Many factors can contribute to a country's tourism development. The media are among the factors that have a significant role in this regard.

Undoubtedly, mass media with vast audiences in all communities can familiarize public with innovations and concepts necessary for development. In this regard, correct and proportionate information dissemination for better communication and change their behavior could be effective. Media play an important role in development and globalization of tourism. It seems that strategic place of media has not been investigated in Iran. TV, press, journals and internet and others could aid in institutionalization of tourism industry in domestic and foreign trips.

Secondary objectives

Paying special attention to the tourism industry which is one of the sectors of tourism in Islam has been considered in many countries of the Islamic areas such as Egypt, Iran, Turkey, Saudi Arabia, Syria, Iraq. Due to possessing old civilization Islamic countries have potential for tourism industry that has been neglected and media was unsuccessful in introducing it in the Muslims world.

Tourism industry position in Iran and world

Tourism as a global system has a significant portion of the world's GDP. Focus Wright Institute of Tourism Information published a report on tourism in Europe. The report states that revenue from tourism market of Europeans ranges from 2.9 billion dollars in 2000 to 10.9 billion dollars in 2002 and in a couple of years, it has grown by almost 300 percent.

Policy of closeness of countries, accurate information dissemination, visa facilitation, extensive facilities and organizing travel extensively for various segments of the Islamic world play a major role in tourism development. It could aid Islamic governments for achieving a common language to develop tourism in Islamic countries.

Application of tourism word is not sufficient it should be offered Islam and its tourism rules and culture to the world. Public awareness by using media is the first principle in development of this industry In Iran. Currently, Malaysia is considered as one of the Islamic countries succeeds in attracting tourists with major investments to disseminate information in different parts of the world. One of the most important principles in tourism is promotion of information within and outside the country. Satellite, magazines, newspapers and internet, brochures and access to information, including problems of small offices and major tourist attraction can be used in this regard. Tourist information must be provided to avoid any problems.

"In Islamic countries, it is necessary to emphasis on tourism attraction and religious beliefs and teachings for identification of this wealthy civilization, while many Muslim countries never use a manner consistent with daily patterns for recognition of their rich culture. Tourism existed in Islam since the past and now it is one of the most important models to attract and promote the beliefs of Islam religion (Untitled, 2010: <http://www.bazarekar.ir>).

The role of media in tourism development

In addition to playing role in communication and information sharing in the society, mass media can function in the political, economic and cultural institutions as well as causing to profound changes in social and cultural scopes and changing certain beliefs and values of society and work as a public university in order to flourish and promote culture and language (Behdarvand, 2002, available at: <http://www.hawzah.net>).

Mass media could develop tourism industry by employing different ways. Directions and procedures of media that influence on strengthening or weakening development of tourism can be categorized in the following categories.

Undoubtedly, mass media including television, newspapers and other media play an important role in attractions of tourists. Mechanisms of distribution and awareness techniques can be news programs, children's historical - cultural series, variety of films, panels, reports, and so on.

Media with wider audiences than any other means in all communities can familiarize the public with new innovations and concepts necessary to understand of tourism development. Media influence and strategic position have not been studied completely in Iran. Television, press, news agencies, professional journals, websites and other media could attract tourists and increase the number of foreign tourists and institutionalize discussion of domestic and inter- country trip with appropriate planning.

Barriers and Strategies

Tourism is field of technology, innovation and application of latest technology to benefit physically and mentally that leads to satisfaction of the visitors , employment of technology and culture of the past and present and offering creative ideas and talent in the future.

Experts believe that Iran with ancient civilization and the nature with four seasons, having hundreds of tourism factors is one of the most unique countries in the field of tourism. Iran with high capacity should be considered as one of the most developed countries in attracting tourists. However, based on statistics a country like the UAE which does not have one -hundredth of the history and culture empowerment of Iran has managed to attract 10 million tourists that this situation is similar for Malaysia in south East Asia. However, despite these potential two million tourists visit Iran annually. The experts believe that if Iran could attract 12 million tourists annually it will have income equals to tens oil barrels and oil income will be replaced by tourism attraction. Websites offer opportunities for introducing tourism attraction in different languages. Official websites could add to effectiveness of the advertisements.

Long term planning on tourism as an income resource and meeting needs is done with direct and indirect instruction and awareness of public of tourism and introducing culture by media such as newspapers, magazines, books, Internet and movies. Thus, in the context of macro programming an essential part is promoting and creating proper atmosphere.

Conclusion

Nowadays living is impossible without information on daily activities and event and mass communication tools. Since humans could progress in material and spiritual scopes only by suing modern mass communications means. Most of the researchers believe that by correct utilization of mass communication tools it can be eliminated poverty and illiteracy and add to public information on agriculture, travel and tourism, horticulture, animal husbandry and various productions in cities and villages by educating the latest methods and techniques in the form of information dissemination.

Accordingly, development of tourism does not necessarily mean to provide facilities but the aim is introducing of culture. Culture and tourism are necessary for change and implementation of this plan requires to media that guides field of tourism.

Tacitly, the role of media in Islamic countries should be defined related to development of tourism and it should be noted that Islamic tourism has neglected as much as media and they have received less attention in Iran.

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